

Chapter 4

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- An introduction to the concept of a standard language and why the idea of a standard language is mythical
- Some dictionary definitions of standard language and the problems with these definitions
- The definitions of standard language as used by laypeople
- A description of Preston's (1989) study of undergraduates' evaluations of "correct" American English by geographical region, and, based on his results, a layperson's description of a Standard American English speaker
- How linguists affect and are affected by standard language ideology
- A discussion of the terminology used in the book to refer to standard (and non-standard) language varieties and racial categories

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. *The Free Online Dictionary's (2009) definition of *SAE is interesting. How does the usage note relate to the definition? Is it complementary, or contradictory?*

Standard American English: The variety of English that is generally acknowledged as the model for the speech and writing of educated speakers.

*Usage Note: People who invoke the term *SAE rarely make clear what they have in mind by it, and tend to slur over the inconvenient ambiguities that are inherent in the term. Sometimes it is used to denote the variety of English prescribed by traditional prescriptive norms, and in this sense it includes rules and usages that many educated speakers don't systematically conform to in their own speech or writing, such as the rules for use of who and whom. In recent years, however, the term has more often been used to distinguish the speech and writing of middle-class educated speakers from the speech of other groups and classes, which are termed nonstandard. ... Thus while the term can serve a useful descriptive purpose providing the context makes its meaning clear, it shouldn't be construed as conferring any absolute positive evaluation. (N.A. 2009)*

Sample Answer: I think the usage note is generally complimentary to the definition. In my analysis, the definition describes what *Standard American English* would probably mean to most people. The usage note then fleshes out this definition by expanding on the idea of a standard language and pointing out ways that most people's understanding of the term *Standard American English* is unsatisfactory. The usage note explains that the definition is based on language ideologies and myths rather than linguistic facts.

2. *English Plus+ (Bair 2009), a website that offers resources to prepare for the SAT, provides a definition of *SAE which covers every possibility:*

Standard American English, also known as Standard Written English or SWE, is the form of English most widely accepted as being clear and proper.

*Publishers, writers, educators, and others have over the years developed a consensus of what *SAE consists of. It includes word choice, word order, punctuation, and spelling.*

Standard American English is especially helpful when writing because it maintains a fairly uniform standard of communication which can be understood by all speakers and users of English regardless of differences in dialect, pronunciation, and usage. This is why it is sometimes called Standard Written English.

There are a few minor differences between standard usage in England and the United States, but these differences do not significantly affect communication in the English language.

Please note that most dictionaries merely report on words that are used, not on their grammar or usage. Merely because a word appears in a dictionary does not mean that it is standard.

How does this definition compare to the others quoted in this chapter? How is it different? Consider the last paragraph especially, which strikes a very different tone. The author seems to be challenging the authority of dictionaries. Why might that be?

Sample Answer: This definition is similar to the other definitions quoted in the chapter because spoken and written language are conflated, there is mention of regional differences but not social ones, and educated people are considered the prototypical speakers of the standard language variety. However, it differs from the other definitions in the last paragraph. Here, the definition seems to caution readers about the dictionary's habit of including non-standard words. This part of the definition challenges the authority of the dictionary, but not in a way that questions standard language ideology. Rather, this challenge to the dictionary's authority seems to criticize the dictionary for not being prescriptive enough in its inventory of words.

3. Consider two statements:

- (1) *The fact that a word appears in a dictionary means ____.*
- (2) *The fact that a word does not appear in a dictionary means ____.*

Can you come up with clear, consistent and factually accurate ways to finish these thoughts? If not, why not?

Sample Answer: I cannot come up with clear, consistent, and factually accurate ways to finish either of these sentences. For the first sentence, I was tempted to say the following:

- (1) The fact that a word appears in a dictionary means that the word has been used by some group of speakers in some context.

I say this because, to my knowledge, lexicographers do not make up words that they have never heard (or seen) to include in the dictionary. However, even this statement is unsatisfactory because there are words that are in use that are not in the dictionary.

The second sentence cannot be completed in any satisfactory way because the fact that a word has not been included in the dictionary really does not mean much. There are many words that are in use that have not yet (or perhaps never will) be included in a dictionary, yet those words and the communities that use them function just fine.

*4. In this book I use *SAE to refer to the concept of a standardized, idealized American English. How does this term fit, or fail to fit? Can you come up with a better solution?*

Sample Answer: I think this term works well because, although it does implicitly keep the standard/non-standard divide alive, the asterisk also calls careful attention to the fact that a homogenized Standard American English is a myth.

From the website

Audio

1. Listen to the samples of Standard American English and Standard British English from the International Dialects of English Archive. Do these examples match up with your expectations of what Standard American and British English sound like? Do you hear speech that sounds like any of these samples where you live?

Sample Answer: These examples match up pretty well with what I imagine Standard American English and Standard British English would sound like. However, these examples also help reinforce the idea that standard language varieties are a myth because there is variation even in these examples, which means that even the samples given for Standard American English are not homogenous. In addition, the clips of “General American” that I listened to only included a reading (rather than natural speech), and in my opinion these samples sound too theatrical to be representative of natural speech.

I do hear speech that sounds somewhat like these samples from some people where I live. However, the speech that I hear around me that I would consider to be close to my idea of the standard sounds a bit different from many of the speech samples offered as “General American” by the International Dialects of English Archive.

2. Review the discussion of Dennis Preston’s (1989) research on standard language ideology in Chapter 4. Then, listen to the speech samples from around the country (Indiana, Mid-Atlantic states, New England, Colorado, West Coast, Michigan, Minnesota, Wisconsin, Ohio, Pennsylvania, Maryland, Delaware, Washington, DC, and New York City) from the International Dialects of English Archive and the Speech Accent Archive. How would each of these samples rank in a list of the areas where the “most correct” English is spoken? How does your list compare to Preston’s findings?

Sample Answer: When I tap in to the linguistic prejudices I had subconsciously carried before taking this course, my list of the most “correct” English aligns with those of Preston’s participants for the most part. One major difference is that, since I am from the West Coast, I listed West Coast English as being the most “correct,” followed by the English spoken in the Midwest and Southwest before moving east and finally south. This is interesting because it shows that, like accents, the idea of what constitutes the “most correct” English is relative.

3. Chapter 4 provides this definition of the word accent from the Oxford English Dictionary (1989):

[Accent is] the mode of utterance peculiar to an individual, locality, or nation, as “he has a slight accent, a strong provincial accent, an indisputably Irish, Scotch, American, French or German accent.” ... This utterance consists mainly in a prevailing quality of tone, or in a peculiar alteration of pitch, but may include mispronunciation of vowels or consonants, misplacing of stress, and misinflection of a sentence. The locality of a speaker is generally clearly marked by this kind of accent.

This definition describes accents as being connected to “mispronunciations, misplacing of stress, and misinflection of sentences.” Listen to the samples of Irish, Scotch, American, French, and German accents from the International Dialects of English Archive. Do you hear anything that you would describe as a mispronunciation, misplacing of stress, or misinflection of a sentence? If so, provide some examples, If not, why not?

Sample Answer: No, I do not hear anything that is a *mispronunciation*, *misplacement* of stress, or *misinflection* of a sentence. I hear *different* pronunciations, *different* stress placement, and *different* inflections on sentences, but no errors. Labeling the variation in these samples as errors implies that there is one variety of English that is correct. Some language varieties are more respected than others, but none is actually better or more correct than another.

4. Chapter 4 also provides the following anecdote from an article examining attitudes about African American English:

I was once lectured by a retired airline pilot at a wedding reception on the difference between African American English and Ebonics; he held that the former was a “legitimate language” and the latter was “that horrible slang you hear on cable TV” (Sclafani 2008: 508).

Listen to some of the clips of African American English from the International Dialects of English Archive. From what you hear in these samples and what you have learned so far in this class, how would you respond to the airline pilot’s comment?

Sample Answer: I would acknowledge his observation that there is variation within African American English, and some varieties of AAE are more respected and accepted by American society than others. However, I would also explain to him that every variety of English, even

those used on cable television, is equally systematic, rule-governed, and expressive. I probably won't be able to convince him of this in one short conversation, but it's worth a shot.

Video

'OMG,' 'LOL' Added to OED

ABC News

<http://abcnews.go.com/US/video/omg-lol-symbol-muffin-top-added-oxford-english-13221130>

This video provides material for discussion of the authority of the dictionary.

1. The reporter in this clip states that OMG, LOL, muffintop, and the heart symbol have been "given literary legitimacy" by being included in the Oxford English Dictionary. Why do you think this story made it on national news? What does this story tell you about common language ideologies in America?

Sample Answer: I think this story made national news because the station anticipated that the inclusion of these terms in the *Oxford English Dictionary* would shock many viewers. I think many viewers would be surprised because they consider the dictionary to be a linguistic authority that decides what counts as a "real word." Many of these same viewers probably don't consider *LOL*, *OMG*, and *muffintop* to be "real words," therefore they might be upset or incredulous about the OED's decision to include them and "legitimize them." The fact that this clip made national news reveals much about language ideologies that marginalize the language of texting and young people as well as language ideologies that give linguistic authority to the dictionary.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Discuss Preston's (1989) study that is described in this chapter. Ask each student to interview 5 to 10 participants and ask each participant to rank the 52 states based on where the most "correct" English is spoken. Compile the results from all the students and see how the results from your area compare to Preston's. What are the similarities? What are the differences? What do the rankings reveal about the language attitudes in your area?
2. Have the students try to find 5 words that they know and/or use that are not in the dictionary, and then find 5 words that are in the dictionary but are totally unfamiliar to them. Ask them to compare and contrast these two sets of words. Why do they think the totally unfamiliar words are in the dictionary while the commonly used words are not?
3. Discuss the myth of Standard American English. Have the students interview a handful of people, asking them to define Standard American English and give examples of who speaks Standard American English. Ask the students to share their results with their classmates and reflect on the standard language ideology in your area in light of what they learned in Chapter 4.
4. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.